

Firefox

Speed Up Firefox's Initial Load Time

On Windows XP, Firefox could be slow to load initially. You might be able to speed this up a bit by using XP's inbuilt prefetcher. Simply right-click the shortcut icon you use to start Firefox. Add the text `"/Prefetch:1"` to the end of the line in the 'target' field. Then, the whole line should look something like this: `"C:\Program Files\Mozilla Firefox\firefox.exe" /Prefetch:1`

The Config File

You can change many more things about Firefox than what is provided in **Tools > Options**. Simply type in `"about:config"` in the address bar, and a whole bunch of configuration settings appear. Right-clicking on a value's name will allow you to modify the value by pressing 'Modify' and entering the new value. Some entries in the configuration file are intuitive; some are not.

Just look at the entire set and you'll be able to decide for yourself what you feel like changing. For example, scroll down to `"browser.download.manager.closeWhenDone"`, and it'll be pretty obvious to you what that setting does. Similarly, `"browser.formfill.enable"` is another setting whose purpose you can guess.

Tune Up Firefox

Go to <http://www.totalidea.com/freestuff4.htm> to download FireTune, a free tune-up and tweaking utility for Firefox. From the page: "According to your computer's speed and Internet connection speed, FireTune will optimise several internal settings of Firefox for better performance. FireTune does not modify the Firefox executable... Everything can be undone easily provided you saved your original profile configuration file."

Control Where Links Open

You can control where new links are opened

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from other applications. For example, say you're browsing a page using Firefox, and you switch to your mail program. There's a new mail with a link to a page your friend told you to check out. When you click it, it will open in either a new window, a new tab or the most recent tab or window. To choose between these three, go to **Tools > Options > Advanced > Tabbed Browsing**. Under 'Open links from other applications in:', choose between 'a new window', 'a new tab in the

most recent window', and 'the most recent tab/window'.

Opening Firefox In Safe Mode

If something goes wrong with a new extension or theme you installed, you can start Firefox in Safe Mode. In Safe Mode, Firefox does not load any extensions, and comes up with the default theme. This way you can uninstall the offending extension or theme and get things back to normal.

To enter safe mode, go to **Start > Run**, and type in the following: `"C:\Program Files\MozillaFirefox\firefox.exe" -safe-mode`

Of course, if Firefox is installed in a different folder, enter the path to that folder instead.

How To Not Save Form Information

As you browse, Firefox keeps a history of what you enter in fields such as search forms. If you don't want it to do this, go to **Tools > Options**, and click the 'Privacy' icon on the left. Go to 'Saved Form Information' and deselect the box that says 'Save information I enter in Web page forms and the Search bar'.

Smart Keywords

Smart Keywords are an easy way to search Web sites right from the location bar. Say you visit IMDb (The Internet Movie Database) often to look up things. You go to imdb.com and click in the search box and enter whatever you're searching for, and click 'Search'. There's a simpler way to do this in Firefox.

With an IMDB Smart Keyword, you can type "imdb Star Wars" into Firefox's Location bar and hit [Enter], and be taken right to the result.

Go to whatever site you want to add a Smart Keyword for, then go to the search box. Right-click in the search box and click 'Add a Keyword for this Search...'. The 'Add Bookmark' dialog will appear. Give the bookmark a name, e.g. 'IMDB Search', and create a keyword, e.g. 'imdb'. File the bookmark wherever you want. Click 'OK'.

Now, enter "imdb Star Wars" into the location bar and press [Enter] and see what happens!

You can repeat these steps for any searches you use—Amazon, your corporate phonebook, an online thesaurus—an site at all!

Add New Engines

Up in the top right corner of Firefox, there's

